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TAMIL NADU

THE STALIN SON RISE

By Amarnath K. Menon

Ending months of speculation, Udhayanidhi Stalin was elevated as Tamil Nadu's deputy chief minister on September 29. The significance of the move is not self-contained: it signals that Chief Minister M.K. Stalin is preparing for assembly polls, slated for the summer of 2026, well in advance. Leader of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) youth wing since 2019, an MLA since 2021 and minister of youth welfare and sports development since 2022, Udhayanidhi is familiar with governance. However, his stint as an understudy of father Stalin has been rather short. In comparison, Stalin had had an apprenticeship that stretched well over three decades. Having started his political career in the early '70s, he was made minister only in 2006. He was 56 when he became deputy CM to his iconic father and five-term CM, M. Karunanidhi, and 68 when he became CM in 2021. Udhayanidhi is now just 46.

The DMK now run unambiguously like a family enterprise, with the help of second- and third-generation loyalists and a well-oiled party rank and file, so the transition at the top is seamless

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE